

Chapter 51-1

The cloth doll was covered in grime, even though Xu Qingzhu had already dusted off quite a bit.

When Liang Shi picked it up, she still got a handful of dust.

It was about the same size as ordinary plush toys that hang on school bags. Through the armpit area, one could vaguely see it was originally lotus pink in color. The facial features had been completely worn away, leaving only a grayish mess.

The needle insertions had no pattern whatsoever—over a dozen needles were densely packed into the small abdomen area.

One leg of the doll had already been torn open at the seams, revealing the cheap cotton stuffing inside.

Liang Shi examined the doll in her palm for a while, lowering her eyes as she pulled out the needles one by one.

They were all ordinary household embroidery needles.

Liang Shi had only seen such things in period dramas before.

She pulled out a total of 12 needles.

Liang Shi arranged them in a row on the bedside table, then looked at that button.

The button wasn't anything special—just an ordinary shirt button.

From its shape, it looked like a cuff button.

What was most distinctive was the bloodstains on the button. It wasn't the button's original red color or dyed pigment—it was blood-red.

It also looked like it had been there for some time.

Liang Shi wasn't a professional and couldn't determine how long the bloodstains on it had existed.

No one had expected to find such things in the room.

They looked quite eerie.

After a long silence, Liang Shi was the first to speak: "Where did you find these?"

Xu Qingzhu replied: "The doll was under the bed near the bedside table, in a very corner spot. This bed probably hasn't been changed—it's extremely dirty underneath, full of dust, looks like it hasn't been cleaned in ages. That button was behind the door, very similar in color to the floor tiles with their cracked pattern. It was probably missed during cleaning and left behind."

Hearing this, Liang Shi bent down and used her phone's flashlight to look under the bed. It was indeed as Xu Qingzhu had described—covered in dust.

The bed's quality wasn't good either. The wooden boards looked quite old. It was the mattress on top that was of good quality—it should be newly replaced and hadn't completely aired out yet.

She tried to find more things, but Xu Qingzhu said: "I've already looked everywhere. Just this doll—the rest is all dust."

Liang Shi swept around once more, then walked to behind the door.

The tiles behind the door were light red with some cracked texturing. When she held the button against the tile, it indeed couldn't be seen.

The discovery of the cloth doll and bloody button made both of them feel uneasy.

Especially since they had both seen that horrifying photograph before.

Although this room was now decorated in a fresh, light style, every spot seemed to correspond with the original layout.

The wind was strong outside, whooshing through the treetops.

Adding several degrees of eeriness.

Liang Shi stayed for a while, then asked gently: "Should we go home?"

Xu Qingzhu hesitated: "Wouldn't that be inappropriate?"

Qiu Zimin had just fainted from arguing with Liang Shi, and now so late at night, Liang Shi still wanted to return to Shallow Water Bay—it didn't look right no matter how you viewed it.

But Liang Shi stood up, took photos of the doll and the row of needles, found a transparent bag to put the bloody button in her pocket, got up and opened the door. Her gentle voice carried a hint of determination: "Let's go. We're going home."

She didn't want to stay in this room.

Xu Qingzhu had always been cautious—after finding that doll, she had taken photos.

On the way back, she sent them to Liang Shi.

Liang Shi chuckled softly: "You're more careful than me."

She had been so angry at the time that she had directly pulled out the needles.

Indeed, she should have left this "evidence" behind.

Xu Qingzhu was responsible for driving.

After the car had driven a distance, Liang Shi called Liang Xinzhou, saying she wanted some quiet time, so she was leaving the old residence first, and asked him not to worry.

Although she didn't want to mention Qiu Zimin, out of respect for Liang Xinzhou, Liang Shi still asked him to take good care of Qiu Zimin.

This night was destined to be sleepless.

Chapter 51-2

//

At the old residence.

Ling Dang had a nightmare and woke up frightened, crying loudly after waking up. Sun Meirou hurried back to comfort Ling Dang.

Yu Wan stayed on the third floor to take care of the unconscious Qiu Zimin.

The two brothers, Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe, went to the study.

Liang Xinhe's brain still hadn't processed this information, asking Liang Xinzhou in disbelief: "Big brother, is this true?"

Liang Xinzhou asked him back: "Does it matter whether it's true or false?"

"It's not that." The usually eloquent Liang Xinhe didn't know what to say for a moment. After pondering, he said: "Whether it matters or not, I still have the right to know the truth."

"It's true." Liang Xinzhou didn't hide it from him either. "You were still young back then. After Third Sister was lost, Dad and Mom had a very tense relationship, because it was Dad who took Third Sister out and lost her. Mom had just given birth not long before and showed some signs of postpartum depression. Later, the psychologist suggested she go out to clear her mind. When she came back, she brought Liang Shi with her."

"So where did Liang Shi come from?" Liang Xinhe asked.

Liang Xinzhou said: "She was found."

"Found where?" Liang Xinhe asked again.

Liang Xinzhou slowly shook his head: "I'm afraid only Mom knows about these things."

He had asked before, but Qiu Zimin only said she was found beside a trash can, looking so small and pitiful that she brought her home to raise.

Qiu Zimin wouldn't say anything more.

If he asked too much, Qiu Zimin would even find him annoying, saying what business was it of a child to manage so much?

Liang Xinzhou had no choice but to bury all of this in his heart.

"What about news of Third Sister?" Liang Xinhe asked. "Haven't we found her after all these years?"

"Mom and Dad have been looking, but there's no news. Those people are extremely cunning—they steal babies and sell them, some even across borders, disguising the stolen children's identities to smuggle them abroad. How could we possibly find her?"

Liang Xinzhou mentioned a heartbreaking incident: "It wasn't just our family that lost children in those years. President Gao, who went out with Dad back then, also lost a daughter. Because of this daughter, his wife divorced him, and he fell into deep guilt. A few years later, when the financial crisis hit and his company went bankrupt, he jumped off a building. They say he was still holding the pen his daughter had grabbed during her first birthday celebration¹ when he died."

Liang's father had also mobilized many connections back then, but found no clues.

Even the leads broke off at the foot of the mountain where they had gone to play. All signs pointed to it being revenge from business rivals.

After that, they could only blame themselves and feel guilty.

Back then, President Gao had spent almost everything searching for his daughter, but a child under one year old couldn't speak and would stop crying with just some food—the difficulty of searching increased exponentially.

Many years passed, technology became advanced, but the cases from years ago became cold cases.

"Recently I noticed that Dongling City cracked a human trafficking case, and some children were reunited with their families." Liang Xinhe said: "What if Third Sister was among them?"

"I've been following that case too. I've already had people investigate—no one meets the criteria." Liang Xinzhou said: "And..."

He paused, then asked very seriously: "Do you really want to find Third Sister?"

Liang Xinhe was stunned: "Shouldn't we look for her?"

"But have you thought about what would happen to Liang Shi if we found Third Sister?" Liang Xinzhou asked gravely.

The study fell silent.

The autumn rain began falling heavily, with large raindrops pattering against the glass. Fine droplets connected into streams winding down the glass before finally flowing to the ground.

Soon, a blinding flash of light streaked across the distant sky, tearing an irregular gash in the gray heavens.

A rumble of thunder followed.

Liang Xinhe's wandering thoughts returned. He understood the implication behind Liang Xinzhou's words.

—They wouldn't search anymore.

"But that's our real sister after all." Liang Xinhe frowned: "Mom and Dad have always wanted to find her, right?"

"After all these years, do you know what she looks like now? Even if we found her, would there be any feelings? If she came back, Liang Shi would definitely leave."

"Where would she go?" Liang Xinhe asked. "Even if Third Sister came back, Liang Shi would still be part of the Liang family. She has no other family members—everything she eats, uses, and lives in is provided by the Liang family. Where could she go?"

"She's acting now, isn't she?" Liang Xinzhou said.

Liang Xinhe was startled, then said dismissively: "How much money can she make from acting?"

"But haven't you noticed she's been cutting expenses?" Liang Xinzhou said: "She hasn't spent a penny on her credit card this month—everything has been from her savings account. I checked her bank statements, and in the past half month, she's only spent less than 1,500 yuan, including 300 yuan in gas."

Liang Xinhe: "..."

When the data was laid out before him, Liang Xinhe finally felt some sense of reality.

But he still didn't quite believe that Liang Shi, who had been spending money like water for so many years, could immediately change this habit.

"I think she's already preparing a backup plan for herself." Liang Xinzhou said: "She probably didn't just learn about this."

Liang Shi's emotions had been very stable, and when discussing this matter with him, it was like talking about someone else's business.

Her attitude was good, but carried a hint of indifference and distance.

"Liang Shi's arrival saved our family, so I owe her this debt of gratitude." Liang Xinzhou looked at Liang Xinhe: "She was also raised by both of us, and we have feelings for her. Even if she was a bit wild outside before, she never caused any major trouble. Moreover, now that she's changed for the better, why should we let another person come in and destroy the existing balance?"

Liang Xinhe fell into deep thought.

Footnotes:

¹ First birthday celebration (抓周): A traditional Chinese ceremony where a one-year-old child is presented with various objects to "grab," believed to predict their future interests or career path.

Chapter 51-3

//

After Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu returned home, the torrential rain had already begun.

There were umbrellas in the car, so neither of them got wet.

By the time they got back, it was nearly dawn. Liang Shi reported her safety to Liang Xinzhou and then returned to her room.

Xu Qingzhu did the same.

The rain was too heavy, and the wind made the windows rattle loudly, with occasional thunder.

Once Liang Shi lay down, her mind was like a revolving lantern, thinking about everything that had happened tonight. She couldn't help but wonder about the situation at the old residence and what Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe would do.

She suffered from insomnia until the latter half of the night, when she got up and took a melatonin tablet.

Only then did she gradually fall asleep.

But Liang Shi had another dream.

Matching this boundless rainy night, it was like falling into endless darkness.

In the dream, she was still in the previous room—dark, enclosed, suffocating.

The ceiling, which looked extremely like a coffin lid, emitted a ghostly red glow. Directly facing the bed in the room was a bronze statue covered with black cloth. White bed sheets were scattered with white paper scraps, as if all the paper from a shredder had been dumped out.

The phone on the bedside table kept lighting up.

Liang Shi stood in this room as an ethereal light and shadow, watching the messages that kept popping up on the constantly brightening screen.

【Cheng Ran: Why are you home again? So annoying, come out and play.】

【Cheng Ran: Damn! Not replying to messages again, I'll break your damn legs next time I see you.】

【Mom: Ah Shi, you absolutely must not lift that black cloth.】

【Mom: That's a deity Mom specially requested for you. Just one week, and it's guaranteed to remove the evil spirits from your body.】

【Mom: Don't tell your brothers either. I'm afraid if they find out, they'll want to drive you away, and Mom won't be able to protect you.】

【Mom: Listen to Mom, absolutely do not lift that black cloth.】

【Mom: What would you like to eat tomorrow morning? Mom will have the servants make it. How about your favorite steamed dumplings?】

After a while, the phone screen finally dimmed.

Liang Shi turned around and saw herself.

To be precise, it was the original host, wearing a blue shirt and black long pants. Her hair was far shorter than now, just past her shoulders. She stood bewildered in the room. After a while, she picked up her phone to check the messages, first sneering coldly, then starting to cry. Low sobbing sounds filled the room.

Soon after, the original host put down her phone. She walked straight through Liang Shi's ethereal shadow and approached the bronze statue covered with black cloth.

Liang Shi really wanted to tell her: "Don't lift it."

Given Qiu Zimin's repeated warnings, she obviously wanted her to lift it.

That thing must be something extremely frightening.

Clearly, the original host also had some apprehension. Her hand fell on the black cloth, hesitating and stepping back several times.

But in the end, she couldn't resist her curiosity.

Her slender fingers lifted the black cloth, revealing the true face of the bronze statue.

Even though she was just a light and shadow, Liang Shi still stepped back half a step in horror.

The face on the bronze statue was her own—and the original host's.

There was no helping it, since they looked identical.

But this wasn't important. What mattered was that this face was imprinted on the bronze statue, with a sinister smile hanging at the corners of its mouth.

The bronze statue's hands held a blade, with the right hand's knife cutting into the left arm's position. This bronze statue had lost its left arm.

As if it had been chopped off by its own right hand.

This seemed like a form of psychological suggestion.

And this bronze statue was kneeling.

It wasn't the deity that Qiu Zimin had claimed at all.

The original host had better psychological endurance than Liang Shi. After seeing this bronze statue, she only laughed lowly, then took a very sharp object from the cabinet—a sharp dagger.

The dagger struck the bronze statue, which swayed like a tumbler toy before finally returning to its original position.

The original host hacked at it like a madwoman until she was exhausted.

Finally, she sat on the ground in exhaustion.

The dagger fell to the ground with a clang.

Watching such an original host, Liang Shi suddenly felt a pang in her heart, an indescribable sadness.

It was like the sorrow of a rabbit at the death of a fox¹.

What Liang Shi hadn't expected was that soon after, the original host picked up that dagger and cut toward her own arm.

Slashing through the blue shirt.

Blood spread everywhere.

Liang Shi desperately wanted to stop this behavior, wanted to snatch the dagger from her hands, but she couldn't do anything.

Here, she was just an ethereal shadow.

The original host's shirt gradually became unrecognizable from its original color. With the final cut, she slashed horizontally at the position parallel to the shirt buttons, and that blue button fell off accordingly.

Stained with blood.

In this extremely oppressive room.

Liang Shi watched the original host harm herself again and again, her eyes becoming increasingly gloomy.

She gradually lost her rationality, yet struggled and wandered on the edge of madness time and again.

She was like a madwoman, yet not completely mad.

Finally, she lay on the ground, looking up at the ceiling and laughing.

Heavy rain poured down, and thunder rumbled.

Her body seemed to fall into an abyss, sinking continuously downward, into the depths of cold darkness that had no bottom.

Footnotes:

¹ The sorrow of a rabbit at the death of a fox (兔死狐悲): A Chinese idiom meaning to feel sad for someone in a similar situation, often used when people of the same kind sympathize with each other's misfortune.

Chapter 51-4

Liang Shi suddenly opened her eyes.

It was dawn.

But the rain outside hadn't stopped yet. Dark clouds still covered the sky, and the clock on the wall pointed to 7:32. Outside it still looked like perfect weather for sleeping, but Liang Shi had just awakened from her dream. She raised her hand to wipe her forehead—it was covered in cold sweat.

She forced herself to sit up, then went to the bathroom to take a shower.

The moment she got out of bed, her legs went weak and she almost fell to her knees.

She took a cold shower in the bathroom, as if only this could calm her down.

Last night's dream had too great an impact on her, and she still felt shaken after waking up.

After showering, she casually wrapped herself in a bathrobe and came out, taking the bloody button from the bedside drawer.

Under the bright light, she could see its original color from the edges.

The original color was blue.

Just like the button that had appeared in her dream.

That wasn't a dream—it was the original host's memory.

Liang Shi had once again obtained part of the original host's memories, and this part carried endless pain.

Even she, an outsider, was moved to pain by it.

Liang Shi seemed to have grasped the pattern for triggering the original host's memories.

After returning to the room at the old residence, she had triggered memories with Zhou Yi'an and Xu Qingzhu.

After seeing the bloody button, she had triggered memories related to the button.

In other words, at key locations or when she touched key objects, the original host's memories would be triggered.

Liang Shi's heart jumped, and she immediately asked the system: "Did you give me the original host's memories?"

After a while, the system's eerie mechanical voice sounded in her mind: 【You don't have the original host's memories?】

Its tone was extremely shocked!

Liang Shi: "No, I've been living blindly this whole time."

The chatty system from before had returned: 【No wonder you've been so OOC¹ all along. So you didn't have her memories. But given your personality, even if you had her memories, you'd still be OOC.】

Liang Shi listened with a headache and said sternly: "Shut up! Get to the point."

System: 【...】

The system was silent for two seconds, then said seriously: 【Sorry host, the original host's memories are not under the jurisdiction of the Resentment Management Bureau. It's up to her to decide whether to grant them.】

"She still has the right to choose?" Liang Shi was shocked.

System: 【From a regulatory standpoint, every person has human rights. The Resentment Management Bureau's human rights laws are very comprehensive. We respect others' privacy and choices.】

Liang Shi found a loophole in its words: "What about privately?"

System: 【...】

【We also respect her choices, because we can only imprison her soul, not take her memories.】
the system said.

Liang Shi rubbed her forehead helplessly, then asked: "So you won't give me a rundown of this book's content?"

System: 【Don't you already know the general content?】

Liang Shi's good temper was gradually disappearing: "I want the details! For example, the relationship between the original host and Qiu Zimin, the original host's background, and what happened after the real daughter came back. Please tell me, thank you."

The system fell silent again.

Liang Shi questioned: "Why can't you tell me?"

The system answered in an eerie voice: 【Have you ever seen anyone write extensively about cannon fodder? Including her background, her past—cannon fodder exists to be abused, to serve as support for the protagonists and then exit the stage.】

Liang Shi: "..."

If the system had a physical form, it would definitely get beaten up.

But after the system disappeared, Liang Shi understood the deeper meaning of its words.

For that book, Liang Shi was just cannon fodder.

There wouldn't be much space devoted to her, so her past wasn't important. Her future was to be cannon fodder, following the timeline to exit the stage.

But for Liang Shi, this was the life she was currently experiencing, the people and events she was dealing with.

Perhaps before, she had still been hesitating about whether to uncover the mysteries surrounding the original host.

She was human, so naturally she had selfish traits.

For her, staying away from the Liang family and not caring about those matters would naturally be best.

But after seeing the original host lying on the ground like a madwoman, she finally made her decision.

She wanted to figure these things out.

Why exactly did Qiu Zimin subject a child to such cruel torment? And why had she existed in this world before?

What exactly had happened between her and the original host?

Who were the original host's biological parents? Why exactly had the original host become that stupid and vicious cannon fodder?

For the author, it might just be one sentence.

But for the original host, for Liang Shi, it was an extremely long lifetime.

Liang Shi would have to live with her original identity going forward, so giving her justice was the only thing she could do for her.

Liang Shi put that button in her pocket and asked Zhao Xuning where there were suitable places for age verification testing.

She smoothly contacted an expert.

While eating breakfast, Xu Qingzhu noticed that Liang Shi had a sharp edge about her.

Before, she had been gentle, like water, very zen-like, not caring about anything.

But at this moment, she seemed to have something she wanted to protect.

"What happened in one night?" Xu Qingzhu wondered.

She carried this thought with her as she left for work.

Footnotes:

¹ OOC: "Out of Character" - a term meaning acting differently from one's established personality or character traits.

Chapter 51-5

//

Time flew by quickly, and soon it was Saturday.

The button Liang Shi had sent to the expert for authentication hadn't yielded results yet. These past few days, only Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe had contacted her, both comforting her emotionally.

She just smiled as if nothing had happened and said: "It's okay."

She hadn't asked about Qiu Zimin, and the other party hadn't contacted her either.

Saturday was the day for her costume fitting photoshoot. This drama was called "Afterglow."

She had defeated Chen Liuying and a crowd of popular idols to compete for this antagonist role.

When Liang Shi arrived at the photography studio, it was still early. As a newcomer actress, she didn't have her own makeup room yet, so she squeezed into the communal makeup room to get her makeup done.

The leads were photographed first. Zhao Ying needed to shoot two versions—one as the early fragile princess pea¹, and another as her grown-up appearance later on, for individual poster shots.

It wasn't until near noon that it was Liang Shi's turn. She wore all black, with rose gold chain glasses. With her slim waist and long legs, wearing the black suit gave her that refined scoundrel vibe.

After seeing her styling and makeup, Zhao Ying couldn't help but sigh: "You're the antagonist herself."

Liang Shi just smiled: "Sister Ying, please don't tease me."

She hadn't shot this type of thing in a long time, so at first she couldn't quite get the hang of it. But after two NGs², she got into character and easily captured the camera's attention. Just one look was enough to express the character's essence.

Even the director couldn't help saying to Zhao Ying: "This one's got potential."

Zhao Ying was proud: "Of course, I picked her out at first glance."

Just as Zhao Ying finished speaking, the click-clack of high heels came through, especially clear on the smooth marble tiles.

The director turned around and saw the investor's wife. He immediately changed his demeanor and went over to greet her: "Mrs. Qi."

The woman wore a blue-green qipao³, her slender legs exposed to the air. Even though she was over fifty, she still had her charm.

Zhao Ying had always disdained dealing with these investors. Her family was wealthy—if she wanted, she could be an investor herself any minute.

So she found a spot to sit and watch Liang Shi's photoshoot.

Liang Shi's costume fitting photos were shot quickly. After finishing, she came down, originally wanting to find Zhao Ying, but her expression changed when she saw the person next to the director.

She frowned, her gaze meeting exactly with Mrs. Qi's incoming look.

Their eyes met.

Footnotes:

¹ Princess pea: Reference to "The Princess and the Pea" fairy tale, suggesting someone delicate and sensitive.

² NG: "No Good" - film industry term for a failed take that needs to be reshot.

³ Qipao: A traditional Chinese dress, also known as cheongsam, characterized by its high collar and form-fitting silhouette.